

Tropical forest

A tropical climate is perfect for plants, because it is always warm and there is no shortage of water. This means that plants grow fast all year, especially large, evergreen trees. The year-round production of leaves and fruit supports an amazing variety of animal species. This makes tropical rainforests the richest of all ecosystems.

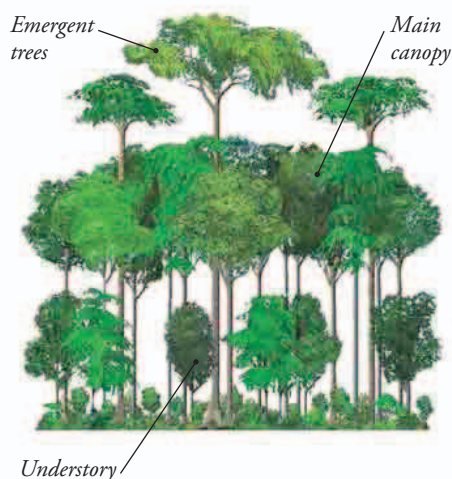


WARM AND WET

Tropical rainforests lie in the hottest parts of the world—in Amazonia, Central America, Central Africa, Southeast Asia, New Guinea, and northeast Australia. The climate is always warm and wet, thanks to the strong sunlight and the huge storm clouds that are built up by the heat.

FOREST LAYERS

A rainforest is a multilayered habitat, with two or three distinct layers of tree canopy above the ground. These are the understory, the main canopy, and the very tall emergent trees that rise high above the others. Each layer has its own wildlife.



▲ FOREST ROOF

The main tree canopy in a rainforest forms an almost continuous layer of foliage.

RAINFOREST

These forests are dominated by tall, broad-leaved hardwood trees such as mahogany, rosewood, and ebony. The dense foliage stops most light from reaching the forest floor, so many of the smaller plants survive as creepers that climb up the trees into the sunlight. Others, such as ferns and orchids, take root in the treetops. Any sunlit areas of ground are smothered by dense undergrowth.

